
The Bergen County Seller's Prep List

What actually adds value, and what's a waste of money

By Tyler Sellers, RE/MAX Signature Homes

When people get ready to sell, they tend to overthink the wrong upgrades. You do not need a \$60,000 kitchen to sell well in Bergen County. You need the handful of things buyers actually notice in the first ten seconds, and the discipline to skip the things they'll just redo anyway. Here is where your money works, and where it doesn't.

Worth it (small spend, real return)

- **Paint, in neutral colors.** The single highest-return move you can make. Fresh, light, neutral walls make a home feel bigger, cleaner, and move-in ready.
- **Declutter and depersonalize.** Pack up half your stuff, the family photos, the countertop pile. Buyers need to picture their life there, not yours. This is free, and it moves the number.
- **A deep, professional clean.** Floors, windows, grout, fixtures. A spotless house reads as a well-maintained house.
- **Fix what an inspector will flag anyway.** The dripping faucet, the loose railing, the dead outlet, missing smoke detectors. Cheap to fix now, expensive as a buyer's negotiation chip later.
- **Light updates with big visual payoff.** Modern light fixtures, cabinet hardware, fresh outlet and switch covers, a clean coat on the front door. Small money, real impact.
- **Curb appeal basics.** Mulch, trimmed bushes, a clean entry, a welcoming front door. It's the first photo online and the first impression in person.
- **Stage the rooms that sell the house.** Living room, kitchen, primary bedroom. Buyers decide fast, so the rooms they decide on have to land.

Waste of money and/or time (skip these before you sell)

- **Full kitchen or bathroom gut remodels.** You rarely make your money back right before a sale, and there's a strong chance the buyer with deep pockets would have picked different finishes anyway.
- **High-end or trendy finishes.** You pay for them, the next owner may tear them out. Save it.
- **Major additions or structural projects.** Long, expensive, disruptive, and almost never worth the time, money, or headache on the way out the door.
- **Pools and big landscaping overhauls.** Polarizing and pricey. Plenty of buyers see a pool as a liability, not a perk.
- **Over-personal upgrades.** The bold accent wall or fancy light-fixture you love can quietly shrink your buyer pool.

The 10-second rule

Most buyers form an opinion in the first ten seconds, at the curb and in the entryway. Put your time and money where that first impression is made: the front of the house, the entry, and the main living spaces. Get those right and you've done most of the job.

A Bergen County note

Buyers here are sharp, they tour a lot of homes, and they expect clean, well-kept, and honestly priced. You don't win them with the most expensive renovation. You win them with a home that feels cared for and a price that makes sense right out of the gate.

Before you spend a dollar

Every house is different, and the smartest move is knowing exactly which of these apply to YOURS before you lift a finger. I'll walk your home with you and tell you where to spend and where to save. Free, no obligation.

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